Q+A

Back in the Game

Mandira Bedi returns as a sports presenter with the Women's Premier League

Q. How does it feel to be back as a cricket presenter?

It feels like home. I gave 15 years to cricket and, after a break, I've come back on a show that is a bit different, as it marries our love for reality shows with our craze for cricket. I am so happy to be a part of it.

Q. What are your thoughts on women playing cricket?

The fact that the WPL is on as we speak is a huge step for women's cricket. When I started my journey around two decades ago, women's cricket wasn't getting its due. There were these wonderful women cricketers, but they never had the money—not until the merger with the BCCI. With WPL, women's cricket has arrived in India. Only a matter of time before it gets the same attention as men's cricket.

Q. How difficult was it for you to find acceptability as a cricket commentator, traditionally a male bastion?

I was never meant to be a cricket expert. I was the presenter who would ask the layperson's questions. The acceptance didn't come easily and the first couple of weeks were disastrous. [But] the channel supported me... There were obstacles. It was a live show, words once uttered could not be taken back. When they saw a woman on the panel, some didn't take it well and wouldn't answer my questions. But the day I started to believe I belonged there, everything changed for me.

Q. Have you ever played cricket yourself?

I've never played cricket professionally. I have, of course, played gully cricket. My father and brother were crazy about it, so I used to enjoy the game. I think that's one of the things people didn't like. In India, if you haven't played the game, you are looked down upon. But my job was not to be an expert, it was to be a presenter and I tried to do that to the best of my ability.

with Rupali Dean



BALVINDER SINGH